

The job is finding a photo you still picture — not a better search box

People start with a fragment of memory. Success is opening the photo they meant. Faster indexing or a smarter keyword rank is a different product.

North-star metric • PRODUCT BET

Successful vague-memory retrieval rate = users who find the intended photo on a vague-memory task ÷ users who start a search with incomplete memory.

Out of scope

Search latency, ranking of exact keywords, and "make search feel faster."

- METRIC DECOMPOSITION

That number only moves if Photos understands the clue the person still has

One bet. The other steps stay healthy; they are not a second product.

Formulate

Turn incomplete memory into a starting clue.

Understand · PRODUCT BET

Accept vibe, object, or episode — not a date first.

Retrieve

Target in the first grouped set.

Recognize

The person opens the intended photo.

Refine

"More like this" or "not this trip."

Sub-metrics: formulation rate, clue-understanding rate, candidate coverage, recognition rate, refinement success, workaround-scroll rate, known-item control success.

Public voice becomes ranked retrieval problems — not a sentiment dashboard

1

Listen

Public photo talk:
stores, forums,
community posts.

2

Keep

Stories about a
failed find. Drop
storage and star-
rating noise.

3

Group

Themes that
share at least two
real quotes.

4

Score

Impact,
feasibility, and
how often it
appears.

5

Drop

"Search is slow" is
not this job.

Research covered: photo kinds people struggle to find, remembered vs forgotten cues, search breakdowns, workarounds, result quality, refinement behavior, and segment differences.

• OPPORTUNITY RANKING

Place without a name is the first problem we will solve.
Generic search we refused.

People remember how a café felt and have forgotten the town.

Opportunity	Impact	Feasibility	Frequency	Node
Place-vibe without name	High	High	High	Understand
Generic search latency	High	High	High	Out of scope
Object + episode	Medium	Medium	Medium	Understand

Top opportunity: place-vibe without a name · Metric: understand · Audience: trip rememberers

The trip rememberer recalls the moment, but not the metadata

Evidence-based behavioral composite of six eligible questionnaire responses—not a demographic profile or a participant quote.

Context

Six trip rememberers with substantial Google Photos libraries described a photo they had tried and failed to find.

What remains · PRODUCT BET

The feeling of the place, the trip or event, and sometimes an activity or object in the scene.

What is missing

The exact date, album, town, or search phrase that would make a conventional query easy.

View the research questionnaire · The study used a structured questionnaire and a 30-minute conversation to reconstruct a failed photo search.

Responses support the problem focus—and reveal what to investigate next

Finding	Product implication
All six eligible records describe a failed first search for a trip/place-vibe photo.	Start from the remembered place or event, not a required date or town.
Normalized notes retain place or event memory while date, album, or town is missing.	Translate that fragment into trip-based candidate groups.
Workarounds include scrolling, asking someone, trying another app, or leaving the photo unfound.	Make the intended photo recognizable in a focused group; counts by workaround are unavailable.

Limits: raw answer totals, unique wording, exact queries, and result grids are not in the repository; no percentages or participant quotes are claimed. Next, capture each person’s clue, query, results, recognition, and workaround, and test trip groups against near-miss photos. Directional evidence from six respondents—not a population estimate.

- THE PROBLEM

People remember how a place felt on a trip and have forgotten the date, album, and town name

Target segment

Trip rememberers with large photo libraries. They recall a trip by its atmosphere, activity, or objects but have forgotten the date, album, or town.

Retrieval scenario

The café I cannot date — a trip photo the person can still picture when capture day and place name are gone.

Product outcome · PRODUCT BET

Understand — the product accepts vibe, object, episode, and fuzzy time. Exactly one node.

Root cause: Search cannot use the clue that remains, even though the photo is in the library. People scroll, ask someone, try another app, or give up. Business risk: a library people cannot re-enter becomes a write-only backup.

- REMEMBER

Remember puts intelligence at the moment of understanding: a vibe in, a trip group out

1

Offer a fragment

Type or speak what is left. Never a date first.

2

See a trip group

Photos groups the trip and says why this set.

3

Confirm or steer

Open the photo, or say "not this trip."

Keyword Search stays the control. Remember is a different path — not a second search box. Intelligence at understand (place-vibe language → grouped candidates).

- RETURN TEST RESULTS

Three return sessions found the café, the trip, and the gig. Keep grouping by trip.

What worked (three return sessions)

In each session, keyword search missed and Remember found the intended photo: a café on a Goa trip, a Goa trip photo, and a concert remembered by its lights.

What to change next · PRODUCT BET

Keep trip grouping with near-miss Europe café. Place-name clue still has to group by trip. Keep vibe-language grouping (lights/gig) and never ask venue or date first.

Three trip rememberers completed retrieval tasks, tried the keyword baseline, and identified a next change. These results use a prototype library, not participants' Google Photos accounts.

- **SUCCESS METRICS & RISKS**

We will know it worked when more of these searches end on the right photo

Leading metrics

- Clue submitted as memory language (without date first)
- Remember accepts place, object, activity, and approximate-time clues
- Intended photo appears in the first grouped set
- Intended photo opened from a group
- Successful find after refining

Risks & mitigations

- Read as "better search" → composer asks for fragment, not "Search your photos"
- Model invents a date or town → ground interpretation in the user's words and reject invented dates or location metadata
- Learned café task success → use a respondent's own task when the original photo can be used

Guardrails: known-date searches should still succeed in Search; Remember must not invent capture dates or location metadata. Metrics are prototype signals, not Google Photos product metrics.